

Participant Guide

Secondary Education Online

This guide is yours. It holds a short summary of each online session and every activity you will work on across the series. Type in the Word version on screen, or print it and write by hand.

Name (optional)

School

Welcome

Across four online sessions you will build a broad, mixed picture of Autistic experience, then turn it into one practical change to a lesson, assessment task or handover, and one purposeful conversation with a family, a student or a colleague.

Taking part online

- Cameras are optional. Turn yours on or off as you need.
- Chat, reactions, speaking, private notes or passing all count as taking part.
- Some activities use small breakout rooms. You can ask to stay in the main room.
- Move, stretch or step away and come back whenever you need to.

How to use this guide

- Each session opens with a one-page summary of the key ideas. Activity pages follow, ready to write on.
- Keep two or three real students in mind across the series. Choose students who differ from each other.
- Use initials or roles only, in this guide, in the chat and in breakout rooms.

The series at a glance

Length	Session	
60 minutes	1	Autism, Sensory and Ways of Thinking
60 minutes	2	Communication, Connection and Daily Capacity
60 minutes	3	Designing for Access Across Secondary School
60 minutes	4	Working in Partnership with Students and Families

The thread through the series

The sessions run on separate days. A few pages carry forward from one session to the next:

Session 1	Think about your students, and a noticing task before Session 2
Session 2	Secondary school-day map and Carry into design
Session 3	My brief, My design, My students check and Commit
Session 4	Bridge, Start · Continue · Reconsider, the conversation plan and the final reflection

Missed a session? Read that session's key ideas page and fill in what you can of its activity pages. At the next session, the facilitator will help you catch up with a partner.

Autism, Sensory and Ways of Thinking

Key ideas

A neurodiversity-affirming approach

Neurodiversity is the whole picture. Autism is one expression of that diversity. Differences are not deficits; all people have strengths and experience challenges; there is no right or wrong way to think, learn or behave.

The social model and dynamic disability

Use an environment-first lens: look for barriers in places, tasks, routines and expectations, and ask what can change around the student. A student's access and support needs may change with the task, environment, relationships and available capacity.

Sensory processing

There are eight senses, not five: touch, vision, taste, hearing and smell, plus proprioception (body in space), vestibular (balance and movement) and interoception (internal body signals). Sensory experience can include pleasure, connection and regulation as well as discomfort or overload. Recognise stimming as authentic expression.

Autistic thinking

- Detail-first processing: noticing details before building the whole picture, with real strengths in pattern recognition and precision.
- Deep focus (monotropism): attention channelled fully into fewer things; shifting attention takes time and warning.
- Executive functioning: planning, organisation, time management, working memory, meta-cognition, emotional regulation, flexibility, attention, task initiation and persistence.

Internal signals

Interoception is noticing and interpreting body signals. Alexithymia is difficulty identifying and describing emotions. Internal experience may not be visible.

ACTIVITY**Think about your students** On your own · private

Bring two or three students to mind, ideally students who are quite different from each other. You will return to them across the series.

Student	Strengths, interests or moments of connection that should stay visible
Student A	
Student B	
Student C	

Use initials or roles only. No names or identifying details.

What are you here for?	What would you like to understand better? You will look back at this in Session 4

ACTIVITY**What did you notice?** After the student voice video

What stayed with you?	What would you like to understand more deeply?

ACTIVITY**Strengths I can see** On your own

Detail-first thinking produces genuine strengths. What strengths do you see in the students you have in mind, and where do they show up?

Student	Strengths I have seen	Where or when I see them
Student A		
Student B		
Student C		

ACTIVITY**Sensory activity** Breakout rooms or on your own

Choose one familiar routine in a class or across the school day. What sensory demands does the environment or task create, and what options could increase access or choice?

Routine:

Sensory demand (environment or task)	Option that could increase access or choice	Question to explore
1		
2		
3		

Notice one familiar routine with the students you have in mind. Bring your notes to Online Session 2.

What supports them

What helps access, connection or joy in that routine?

What adds demand

What seems to make it harder, and when?

What I do not know yet

Write it down as a question to explore.

Communication, Connection and Daily Capacity

Key ideas

Communication is multimodal

Speech is one part of communication. How much someone speaks does not tell us how much they understand. AAC (augmentative and alternative communication) is part of communication access. Clear communication, processing time and visual supports help; the right support depends on the person and the moment.

Double empathy and connection

Misunderstanding can happen in both directions between people with different experiences and communication styles. Connection does not need to look one way, and can happen with family, at school, in the community and online.

Managing daily capacity

Think of a student's energy as a battery, or a set of spoons. Every day starts with a different charge; every action uses some; the right supports can recharge it. A moment that seems small may sit within many demands across the day.

Six classrooms, six teachers, one student

Every period change brings a new room, adult, set of expectations and sensory setting. Each teacher sees one part of the day. Sharing what works across those teachers is something a school can plan for.

Masking, identity and belonging

What is visible does not tell the whole story. The pressure to fit in is often highest in the secondary years, and masking often increases. Burnout and School Can't can build up over time. A young person who knows who they are, and feels genuinely valued for it, has more available for everything else.

Where do the students you have in mind spend recess and lunch, and who with?

What kinds of connection does each of them enjoy? (Shared interests, gaming, sport, music, clubs, online communities, being together quietly?)

Which parts of the day are socially hardest for them: group work, corridors, the canteen, PE?

What could teachers change to make connection easier, without putting them on the spot?

Use a real timetable for one of your students, or the sample Year 9 timetable on the next page. Go period by period. For each student, note what the period asks of them and whether anything gives energy back.

Mark: **C** costs energy **L** lightens or gives energy back **?** not sure yet

Period	Room, teacher, what happens	Student A	Student B	Student C
Arrival				
Home group				
Period 1				
Period 2				
Recess				
Period 3				
Period 4				
Lunch				
Period 5				
Period 6				
Departure				

Use this if you do not have a real timetable for one of the students you have in mind.

Time	Period	Subject and room	Teacher	What is happening today
8:30	Before school	Locker bay, yard or library		Crowded and noisy. Bags, lockers, finding friends.
8:45	Home group	Room C4	Home group teacher	Notices read out quickly. Timetable change mentioned once.
8:55	Period 1	English, Room B12	English teacher	Instructions given out loud for a writing task.
9:45	Period 2	Science, Lab S3	Relief teacher today	Practical lesson. Different seating plan.
10:35	Recess	Canteen and yard	Staff on duty	20 minutes. Canteen queue.
10:55	Period 3	Maths, Room B7	Maths teacher	A short quiz is announced at the start of the lesson.
11:45	Period 4	PE, change rooms and oval	PE teacher	Changing in the change rooms. Outdoor team game.
12:35	Lunch	Anywhere on the grounds	Staff on duty	40 minutes. Clubs run in the library.
1:15	Period 5	Humanities, Room C10	Humanities teacher	Group work on a project. Groups chosen by the teacher.
2:05	Period 6	Visual Art, Art room	Art teacher	Assessment task handed out, due in three weeks.
2:55	End of day	Bus bay		Home by about 3:40.

Six periods, six different teachers, a relief teacher, a practical lesson, changing for PE and an assessment task at the end of the day. No single teacher sees all of it.

Costs

What adds demand or uncertainty?

Lightens

What reduces demand? What restores capacity or brings joy?

Where is a student's experience unknown?

Which classes, teachers or times of day ask the most of them to appear "fine"?

Where at school do they seem most able to be themselves?

Who would notice if they were struggling, and how would that reach the right people?

Choose from your day map.

Keep

One practice to keep because it supports access, connection or joy

Reduce

Bring this to Session 3

One barrier or unnecessary demand to reduce

It is a: ☐ lesson ☐ assessment task ☐ handover

Explore

One question to explore with students, families or the team

Designing for Access Across Secondary School

Key ideas

Students come first

Move from understanding to design without turning students into a list of problems. Start with the real students you have in mind, a specific access question and evidence from your day map.

Design the change, then check it

This session designs one change to a lesson, an assessment task or a handover. You design it universally first, then check it against each of your students.

Options to draw on

- Executive functioning meets assessment: publish schedules early, chunk tasks with visible milestones, show an exemplar and make submission steps literal.
- Predictability across the timetable: clear information about routine and change, in every class and on relief days. Predictability is access to information, not a promise that nothing will change.
- Supports that travel: a one-page profile, written with the student and shared with every teacher, including relief teachers.
- Visual supports: clarify what students need to find, understand, remember or communicate.

Universal first, then the continuum

Universal Design for Learning offers more than one way to access, engage and respond. Where a design still doesn't work for someone, support continues along a continuum: inclusive environment, universal supports, targeted supports, then individual adjustments, recorded through NCCD processes and levels of adjustment.

ACTIVITY**My brief** On your own

My focus (a lesson, task or handover):

It is a: ☐ lesson ☐ assessment task ☐ handover

This asks students to...

For some students, that means...

We could change...

☐ Specific, workable, and free from blame or deficit labels

ACTIVITY**Options I chose** After the inputs

- ☐ Executive functioning meets assessment
- ☐ Predictability across the timetable
- ☐ Supports that travel
- ☐ Visual supports
- ☐ Something else

Why it fits: which demand in my brief does it answer?

ACTIVITY**Accessibility check** Run these over your draft

- ☐ Can students find and understand what they need?
- ☐ Can they take part in more than one way?
- ☐ Can they pause, ask for help or recover?
- ☐ Is the support available when demand increases?

What I adjusted:

ACTIVITY**Quick review of a visual support** If your design uses one

- ☐ Can the student understand it?
- ☐ Can they access it when they need it?
- ☐ Does it reflect what is actually happening, including change?
- ☐ Does it provide useful information or a way to respond?

1 The barrier or unnecessary demand

2 The change to the environment, task or routine

3 How students' communication and experience are included

4 What I will observe

5 When I will review it

☐ Checked in a breakout pair: still student-centred and environment-first

ACTIVITY
My students check On your own · private

Hold your design up against each of the students you have in mind.

	Helps	No difference	Needs something more
Student A			
Student B			
Student C			

Where the design still doesn't work for someone, that is where targeted or individual support begins.

ACTIVITY
Commit Before you leave

This week, in my own classes	With my faculty or year level team	To raise with school leaders

Who I will involve Including the student and family	How the student and family will help refine it

Working in Partnership with Students and Families

Key ideas

Where partnerships converge

Students, families, school staff and support staff each bring different knowledge and a different relationship with the student. The student is at the centre of every partnership.

Power dynamics

Power can sit in socio-economic status, historical and cultural experiences of education, language, understanding of school systems, and the perceived importance of school. It is also present in meeting structures, language and decision pathways.

Consultation literacy

Useful consultation has a clear shared purpose, open questions, more than one way to contribute, respect for student and family knowledge, accurate recording and an agreed action with follow-up. Ask, listen, and follow up.

Adolescents in their own meetings

Move from talking about students to having them take part and, over time, lead their own meetings. Speaking up for themselves now is practice for senior school, work and life after school.

When student capacity runs out

Meltdown, shutdown and School Can't are discussed without blame. Home and school may observe different parts of the student's experience. Focus on safety, what preceded the situation, what supports recovery and what can change.

Belonging, capacity and joy

Belonging: being recognised, included and able to participate as oneself. Capacity: what the day costs, protects and restores. Joy: interests, connection and authentic expression. Return to these when judging whether a change supports flourishing.

ACTIVITY**Power dynamics** Chat, whiteboard or private notes

An imbalance from a home perspective	An imbalance from a school perspective	How I could address these imbalances

ACTIVITY**Student voice** After the video

What decisions were made, and who made them?	What impact did those decisions have on Adon?	How are the students I have in mind asked and heard?

ACTIVITY**Consultation checklist** For your next meeting

- ☐ A clear, shared purpose
- ☐ Open questions
- ☐ More than one way to contribute
- ☐ Respect for student and family knowledge
- ☐ Accurate recording of what was heard
- ☐ An agreed action, responsibility and follow-up

ACTIVITY**Bridge to the next family conversation** On your own

Prepare for one purposeful conversation.

What needs to be understood?

What question will open the conversation?

How will the student take part, or have their views included?

What can be decided together?

How and when will the school follow up?

Start

One strategy to start, something small you can start next week

Continue

One practice to continue, something this series confirmed you already do well

Reconsider

One approach to reconsider, something you would now do differently

How will I know it worked?	What evidence will show it?

This plan is yours. Your Session 3 "this week" change can be your Start.

Choose the real conversation you'll have within two weeks, with a student's family, the student themselves, or a colleague who teaches them.

What I'll share A strength first	What I'll ask Specifically	What I'll offer

My opening sentence, word for word

When	Where	How

Turn back to "Think about your students" in Session 1. Read your own words. What's different now?

Where was I at the start of Session 1?	Where am I now?

What will I do differently in my teaching?

Answer it in one sentence, for yourself.

Connections that continue

This series is a starting point. These supports continue after it.

Webinars and deep dives	Follow-ups on UDL, executive functioning, sensory design, anxiety and more. [Titles, dates and links to confirm]
Online Community of Practice	A place to keep talking with other educators after this series. [Link or QR code to add]
Positive Partnerships	positivepartnerships.com.au
Visual Supports Checklist	A practical resource for reviewing an existing support or planning a new one. [Where to find it, to confirm]
NCCD	NCCD Meetings Tool Kit and current official NCCD information: nccd.edu.au
Disability Standards for Education	Getting started; Advocating with and for your child; Milestones and transitions (Department of Education)
Autism Connect	National autism helpline: 1300 308 699
Disability Gateway	1800 643 787
Carer Gateway	Emotional, practical and financial support for carers: 1800 422 737

My notes
